

in the thought of putting it on the auction block with the other billions of shares. After the NYSE tour guide finished her spiel, I stood in line with a dozen or so other investors in America, waiting to peck at one of the three Quotron machines provided for public use. The man ahead of me did a delightful little jig to the up-to-the-minute price on his stock. I pecked in "ATSI," the symbol for Angstrom, only to see that it had fallen a sixteenth more, from $1\frac{3}{4}$ to $1\frac{11}{16}$, and further below my break-even point.

My attention was diverted by a man at the neighboring Quotron, who asked: "Do you know the symbol for Brooklyn Gas?" I said I didn't. He was tall and gawky, and he wore a long coat more tattered than mine. When I heard him mumble "It's going down when it's supposed to be going up," I suspected this was a fellow average investor. He identified himself as Lester Schwartz, a science teacher from Brooklyn who liked to visit the stock exchange on his lunch hour.

We walked together up the ramp to the viewer's gallery as Mr. Schwartz related his investment history. It was a sad progression, beginning with: "I made \$10,000 on one of those bond-recall deals. That was great." From there, things degenerated from "great" to "pretty good" to "pretty lousy." Soon, he got to the part about how he'd decided to steer clear of all stocks after a long run of horrendous losses, when he'd been lucky just to break even. "I've got all my money in Treasuries now, and the rest you can forget it," he said. "Except for this one other thing—Brooklyn Union Gas. It's supposed to be going up, and its going down."

As we approached the large picture window that overlooks the trading floor, Mr. Schwartz confessed that he'd been fibbing to me most of the way up the ramp. He admitted that he was still in and out of all kinds of stocks, and not just the Brooklyn Union Gas Company. "Put a bug into my head, I'm a goner," he confided. He also admitted he wasn't a science teacher anymore. He'd only been a science teacher until he got stock fever and quit his job. He was inspired by a close friend who lived out of a suitcase, slept in his Corvette, and played the markets.

"Your friend got rich?" I asked.

"No, actually he didn't," said Lester. "But he had a broker who did."